

Senegal



Senegal's capital, Dakar, stands on the westernmost cape of Africa. After independence from France, Senegal became a single-party state, but it has had multiparty elections since 1981.



GEOGRAPHY

Arid semidesert in the north. The south is mainly savanna bushland. Plains in the southeast.



CLIMATE

Tropical, with humid rainy conditions June–October, and a drier season December–May. The coast is cooled by northern trade winds.



PEOPLE & SOCIETY

Interethnic marriage has reduced ethnic tensions. Groups can be identified regionally. Dakar is a Wolof area, the Senegal River is dominated by the Toucouleur, and the Malinké mostly live in the east. The Diola (Jola) in Casamance have felt politically excluded, prompting a long-running secessionist struggle; a cease-fire has held since 2004. A large diaspora has raised global awareness of Senegalese culture and music.



THE ECONOMY

Good infrastructure, particularly port at Dakar. Fishing (though stocks diminishing). Remittances. Phosphate mining. Groundnuts. Development of tourism. Oil potential off Casamance.



INSIGHT: *Senegal's name derives from the Muslim Zenaga Berbers who invaded in the 1300s*



FACTFILE

OFFICIAL NAME: Republic of Senegal

DATE OF FORMATION: 1960

CAPITAL: Dakar

POPULATION: 12.5 million

TOTAL AREA: 75,749 sq. miles
(196,190 sq. km)

DENSITY: 169 people per sq. mile

LANGUAGES: Wolof, Serer, Pulaar, Diola, Mandinka, Malinké, Soninké, French*

RELIGIONS: Sunni Muslim 90%, traditional beliefs 5%, Christian 5%

ETHNIC MIX: Wolof 43%, Serer 15%, other 14%, Peul 14%, Toucouleur 9%, Diola 5%

GOVERNMENT: Presidential system

CURRENCY: CFA franc = 100 centimes